RAJWANT RAWAT



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR



NOW **Milling with people out for Diwali shopping, Oct. 15, 2022**

2,678
NEW CASES
The number recorded on Oct. 14, as against 414,000 on May 6, 2021, at the peak of the Delta wave

90
PER CENT
Indians who now have hybrid immunity, i.e., both natural and vaccine-acquired, against the virus

8
DEATHS
The number recorded on Oct. 14, as against 3,915 deaths on May 6, 2021, when Delta wave was at its height

<70
DEATHS
The daily average for the past six months

90
PER CENT
Empty Covid beds in Kerala, the state with the highest number of active cases

1
PER CENT
The share of Covid patients in Kerala who have serious illness

(Source: MoHFW)

the virus, robbing it of the ability to cause severe disease? "The Delta wave was the most baffling and disturbing," says Dr Kataria. "Young, healthy patients were completely okay one minute and gasping for air the next. The slide from normal to severe was super quick." However, she hasn't seen a serious case since the end of the last major wave in February 2022, and gets no more than a handful of patients every month.

Dr Rahul Pandit, director of critical care at Fortis Hospitals, Mumbai, and member of the National Covid-19 Task Force, endorses her observation. "You aren't seeing 400,000 new cases each day as we did with Delta, or 300,000 new cases as we saw at the peak of Omicron," he says. "I haven't seen a single Covid patient in the hospital in the past 10 days and no more than one or two a month in the past six months."

Other indicators bear this out. Wastewater surveillance, an initiative of the Tata Institute for Genetics and Society (TIGS) and CCMB-CSIR, in Hyderabad, Pune and Bengaluru, has indicated that even if there is infection, it is nowhere near alarming levels. Dr Rakesh Mishra, director of TIGS, says that a minor surge was noticed during Dussehra season in Bengaluru, but overall cases are declining. "Even if people don't go in for RT-PCR tests, the viral load will be present in wastewater. The numbers have reduced to the point where we will now test every two weeks instead of weekly."

However, Dr Virander Singh Chauhan, geneticist and former director of ICGEB (International Centre for Genetic Engineering and Biotechnology), stops short of saying the pandemic is over. Instead, he believes the virus will continue to infect many and we will learn to live with it. "The knowns," he says, " are this: